The Lantern Keeper

A short story for testing

Chapter One
The Storm

The wind had been rising since noon, and by the time the light failed over the harbour the whole island seemed to lean away from the sea. Mira climbed the last turn of the lighthouse stairs with the oil can knocking against her knee, counting the steps the way her grandfather had taught her, because counting kept the dark from getting into your head.

Old Tobias was already at the top, bent over the great lens with a rag in his hand. He did not look up when she came in.

“You’re late,” he said.

“The ferry didn’t run,” Mira replied. “I had to walk the long way round, past the quarry.”

“Past the quarry? In this?” He finally turned, and the lamplight caught the deep lines of his face. “Girl, you could have gone straight over the edge and nobody would have found you until spring.”

“But I didn’t,” she said, setting the can down. “I’m here, aren’t I?”

Tobias grunted, which was the closest he ever came to saying he was glad. Outside, the first heavy drops

began to hammer the glass, and somewhere below them a shutter banged loose and kept banging, over and over, like someone knocking to be let in.

They worked without talking for a while. Mira trimmed the wicks while the old man polished the brass, and the beam swept out across the water in its slow, patient circle: north, east, south, west, and back again.[1]

"Tobias," she whispered at last, "did you hear that?"

"Hear what?"

"Down there. On the rocks. It sounded like a bell."

He was quiet for a long moment. Then he set the rag down very carefully, as though it might break.

"There's no bell on those rocks," he said softly. "Not anymore."

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[1] The keepers of the northern lights were required to log every rotation failure, however brief.

Chapter Two
The Boy on the Rocks

By midnight the storm had found its full voice. Mira pressed her face to the cold window and stared down at the black water until her eyes ached, and then she saw it: a small shape on the rocks below the tower, pale against the foam, one arm raised.

"There's someone down there!" she shouted. "Tobias, there's a child on the rocks!"

The old man was beside her in two strides. For a second neither of them breathed.

"Stay here," he ordered. "Keep the light turning. Whatever happens, keep it turning."

"I'm coming with you!"

"You are NOT," Tobias roared, and the force of it made her step back. Then, more gently, "If the light goes out, every boat between here and the mainland is lost. Do you understand me, Mira? Every one."

She nodded, though her throat had closed up so tightly she could not answer. He was gone down the stairs before she could find her voice again, and she was alone with the turning lens and the roar of the sea and the terrible, steady ticking of the clockwork that drove it.

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When the door finally banged open below, it was nearly three in the morning. Mira flew down the stairs so fast she nearly fell. Tobias stood dripping in the doorway with a boy wrapped in his coat, a thin, shivering thing of perhaps eight or nine, with enormous dark eyes and hair plastered flat to his skull.

"Is he alive?" she breathed.

"Alive and furious about it," Tobias said, and to her astonishment he laughed, a great cracked bark of a laugh. "Bit me twice on the way up. Fetch blankets, and put the kettle on the stove."

The boy glared at them both from inside the coat. "I wasn't drowning," he muttered. "I was waiting."

"Waiting for what?" Mira asked.

The boy looked at the floor. "For the bell," he said. "My mother said that if I ever got lost, I should follow the bell."

Chapter Three
Morning

The storm blew itself out a little before dawn. Mira woke in the chair by the stove to find the boy, whose name turned out to be Pell, sitting cross-legged on the floor and eating bread with the steady concentration of someone who had not eaten in days.

Tobias was at the table with the old logbook open in front of him, turning the brittle pages one by one. His face was grey in the early light.

"What is it?" Mira asked.

"Forty years ago," he said slowly, "there was a ship called the Margaret Hale. She went down on those rocks in a storm just like last night's. There was a bell on her deck, the old kind, that the sailors rang in fog." He tapped the page. "Her captain's name was Pell."

Nobody said anything. Outside, the gulls had begun to cry, and the sea lay flat and shining and innocent, as if it had never been anything else.

"That's silly," Pell said at last, with his mouth full. "That's just my name."

"Of course it is," Tobias said gently. He closed the logbook, and Mira saw that his hands were shaking. "Of

course it is, lad. Eat your bread."

But later, when the boy had fallen asleep in front of the stove and the morning ferry was already a dark speck crossing the bay, Mira went up to the lamp room alone. She stood for a long time looking down at the rocks, and although the air was perfectly still and the sea was perfectly calm, she could have sworn that, very faintly, somewhere below her, a bell was ringing.